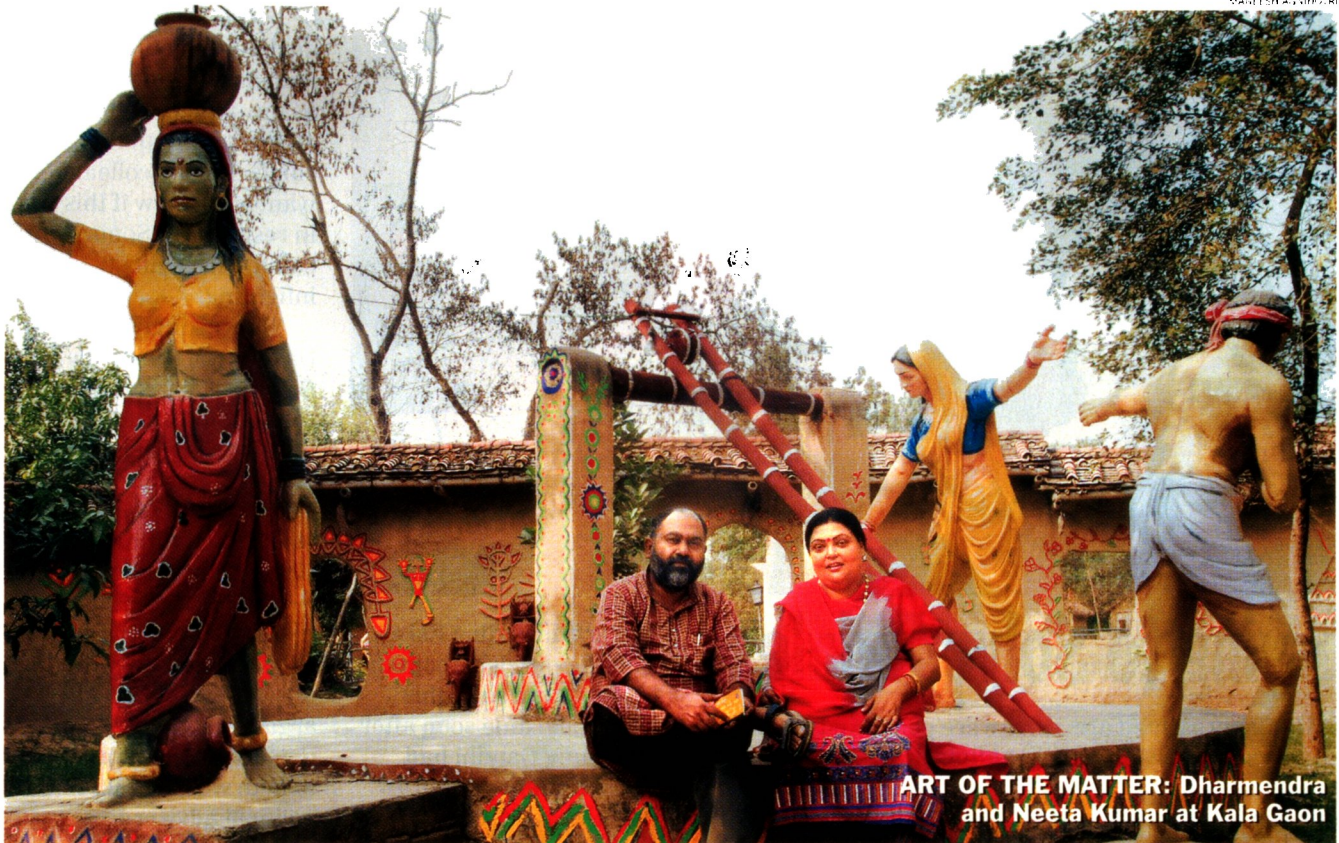




ART OF THE MATTER: Dharmendra and Neeta Kumar at Kala Gaon

In Rustic Retrospect

A replica of a typical Awadhi village promotes folk art and offers an authentic rural experience

■ **By Farzand Ahmed**

A 40-minute drive from Lucknow, along the picturesque Indira canal, is a typical Awadhi village untouched by modernity. As you enter the tree-lined hamlet, a woman, clad in a colourful sari, draws water from a well, as another balances an earthen pitcher on her head. Only, these are not real people, but larger-than-life figurines. Welcome to Kala Gaon, a four-acre dream world painstakingly created by 43-year-old sculptor Dharmendra Kumar and his 40-year-old painter-wife Neeta, with the help of students from the Lucknow College of Art, which is also the couple's alma mater. The sprawling set-up, located on the Lucknow-Faizabad highway near Anaura, looks every bit like a village. Amidst rows of huts made of mud and straw, rural folk carved out of stone and clay appear to be singing, grinding wheat and churning butter in pots. A bullock-cart, a tastefully-decorated bridal palanquin and a horse-driven car, called an *ekka*, stand parked. To complete the experience, the place is dotted with granaries, curd-making pots and other rural essentials.

Launched in February last year with a budget of Rs 70 lakh, Kala Gaon has over 40 sculptures on different aspects of rural life. On paying a fee of Rs 111, visitors can get a slice



of Uttar Pradesh's village life. The ticket cost includes a typical rural meal—cooked in a *handi*, or an earthen pot—of roti, *missi* roti, rice, dal, vegetables, pickles and kheer. There is a full-fledged crafts bazaar, where artisans sell hand-made products. "We have tried to create an authentic village. We want to revive folk art and craft," says Kumar. Clearly, the

concept has hit bullseye. A favourite spot for picnics, wedding ceremonies and seminars, Kala Gaon already attracts 50-60 people every day, with the number of visitors going up during the winter months.

The 'village' is also home to an art gallery, a permanent *kathputali* (string puppet) theatre from Rajasthan and open-air theatres where *nautanki*, story-telling sessions and seasonal dances are regularly organised. For a period of 40 days, beginning with *basant*, the spring season, and ending with *chait*, the beginning of summer, the place is abuzz with cultural activities. Kala Gaon recently organised the Nautanki Mahotsav for the first time in a bid to revive the dying folk art form of musical street plays based on mythological tales or folklore. The month-long Rajasthani folk art festival is currently on. Reminiscent of a different time and age, the landscape of Kala Gaon is a gentle reminder to city-dwellers that India still lives in its villages. ■